

For much of the twentieth century, the promise of a good hotel was remarkably simple: wherever in the world you arrived, you knew what awaited you. As international travel expanded after the Second World War, hotel companies codified brand standards, operating procedures and service rituals so that a traveller arriving in an unfamiliar city could still recognise the product. In periods of uncertainty, consistency offered comfort.

In India, however, hotel development has historically followed visible demand. Weddings, corporate travel, MICE (meetings, incentives, conferences and exhibitions) and established leisure circuits offered clearer economics than venturing into destinations without a proven demand for luxury. As a result, hospitality often expanded where tourism already existed rather than helping create new tourism geographies.

Then, once polished marble, enormous lobbies, buffets, ballrooms and impeccable service became things that money could reliably buy, they stopped being enough to differentiate luxury. Luxury is moving from abundance to specificity: privacy, provenance, cultural access, local knowledge and experiences that are difficult to reproduce elsewhere.

The spending patterns of India's affluent consumers increasingly reflect that shift. Visa Consulting & Analytics' India's Affluent Economy 2025–2026 found that travel accounts for 58 per cent of discretionary spending among Ultra Elite consumers — more than any other discretionary category. More broadly, the study points to a movement away from ownership as the primary expression of luxury, towards access, curation and bespoke experiences. For hospitality, that changes the proposition: the value of a stay increasingly lies not simply in what a hotel contains, but in what it enables a traveller to actually experience.

At its best, a hotel today can become a microcosm of its destination. Rather than serving merely as the place from which a traveller ventures outward, it can become part of the reason for making the journey at all. That is where the next phase of boutique hospitality becomes particularly interesting.

Its opportunity is not merely to build better hotels, but to participate in destination creation itself. In places such as Trasi-Maravanthe, where Karnataka is investing in coastal tourism development, carefully conceived hospitality can help open an emerging tourism geography to a new kind of traveller rather than competing for share in an already mature market. To open on a working tea estate at Durrung in Assam, in Leh, or along a secluded



In Stok Kangri, a royal village across the Indus from Leh (Above); Zero metres from the Arabian Sea, The Postcard on the Arabian Sea is a nine-room retreat (Left) a private stretch of Maravanthe Beach. Timber-lined dining spaces open onto lush gardens, with the shore just beyond